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SUSTAINABLE HUMAN RESOURCE MANAGEMENT IN THE GIG ECONOMY: A STUDY OF WORKER WELL-BEING, CAREER SUSTAINABILITY, AND HR PRACTICES

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ABSTRACT:

The growth of the gig economy has transformed traditional employment through flexible and platform-based work, while also creating concerns related to job insecurity, income instability, social protection, and career growth. This study examines the role of Sustainable Human Resource Management (SHRM) in improving gig workers' well-being and career sustainability, with focus on health, job satisfaction, financial stability, work-life balance, skill development, and employability. Using a descriptive and analytical approach, the study draws on primary and secondary data collected through surveys and interviews with workers from selected gig platforms. The findings aim to identify gaps in existing HR practices and support the development of sustainable, human-centred strategies that address both worker well-being and organizational objectives.

Keywords: *Gig Economy, Sustainable Human Resource Management, Worker Well-being, Career Sustainability, Job Security, Skill Development, Labor Laws.*

1. Introduction

Although as rosy it may look , it also presents a list of challenges such as lack of job security, restricted employment benefits, irregular revenue and minimal legal support. Unlike traditional employment , Gig work providing platform are not currently covered under labor laws. Because of absence of coverage from the labor laws gig workers faces many challenges. The lack of minimum wages, health insurance , retirement benefit raise concerns among workforce.

In this scenario the concept of Sustainable Human Resource Management (SHRM) has gained massive attention. The practices of SHRM consist of integrating economic, social and environmental objectives into HR practices. The major objective of SHRM is ensuring long term organizational success while also promoting well being and societal development of employees. Implementing SHRM principles in gig economy means involving innovative ways to engage, support and manage a workforce with is external , widely spread and digitally connected. The working condition in gig economy can be unpredictable and demanding. This creates a challenge for HRM to ensure not only physical health but also psychological stability, job satisfaction, and financial security are meet. In recent years the concept of career sustainability is also getting mass recognition. Gig work requires workforce to continuously adapt and upgrade their skills which creates a tedious to maintain employability in massively competitive and ever changing environment. Gig economy at present lack structured growth opportunities which creates a question of career sustainability.

Human Resource practices play a crucial role in addressing these challenges. Although Gig workers are not always formal employees through HR strategies an organizational can be more inclusive for them. They can be made inclusive be using HR strategies such as skill development programs, fair compensation models, transparent communication systems, and mechanisms for worker feedback and participation. In continuous run this will surely support to build trust, enhance worker satisfaction, and promoting long-term engagement.

This study aims to explore the intersection of Sustainable Human Resource Management and the gig economy. This is done to analyze that how organization can design and implement sustainable HR strategies to improve organizational performance along with ensuring welfare and development of Gig workers. The study is done to give better prospective of how HRM can evolve to meet the demands of a ever changing world of work. It examine the existing challenges and highlights the potential solutions that can contribute to solve these challenges. While giant business organizations continues to prioritize their cost efficiency , profit and operational flexibility some what fair and ethical treatment is sidelined. Business Organizations must recognize gig workers as an integral part of their operation chain and there is need of implementing policies

that promote inclusivity, equity, and long-term engagement. The HR strategies that can be included are learning opportunities, fair incentive system and grievance redressal mechanism. The study observed that organisations are implementing various digital tools to enhance productivity and communication.

The absence of appropriate labor laws for gig workers often leads to exploitation , job dissatisfaction and career uncertainty. Human Resource Policymakers and Labor regulatory bodies plays a crucial role in supportive gig economy. These institutions need to develop a framework that safeguards the gig workforce rights and welfare. Collaborative efforts between organizations, governments, and platform providers can help create a ecosystem where flexibility and security coexist. The integration of SHRM can ensure that the growth of the gig economy remains both inclusive and sustainable in the long run.

2. Literature review

The concept of gig economy has attracted significant attention of academic and industry. The transformation in the nature of work and relationship between organisation and gig labors. The impact of this transformation has been explored by any researchers.

This has been observed that implementation of emerging principles like SHRM can provide a framework that can address social ,economic and ethical challenges associated with modern workforce practices.

De Stefano (2016) expressed gig economy as a indication of shift from traditional employment to demand based economy facilitated by digital platforms. His study highlighted the legal and regulatory challenges which are faced by gig workers in relation to classification of employment and rights. **Kalleberg and Dunn (2016)** expressed that non-standard forms of employment which includes gig work often showed working conditions characterized by lack of job security and limited access to benefits. The concerns of work gig workers have been widely discussed in the literatures. The aspect which has gained researchers attention is career sustainability. Researchers have explored the career sustainability in the literatures. **Wood et al. (2019)** argue that while gig work offers flexibility and autonomy, it can also result in increased work intensity, isolation, and stress, negatively affecting mental health. In contrast, some studies, such as **Hall and Krueger (2018)**, suggest that certain gig workers experience higher job satisfaction due to flexible schedules and independence, indicating that the impact on well-being may vary depending on individual circumstances and job characteristics.

From the perspective of Sustainable Human Resource Management, **Ehnert (2009)** defines SHRM as an approach that integrates sustainability principles into HR practices to ensure long-term organizational success while promoting employee well-being. **Kramar (2014)** further expands on this concept by

emphasizing the need for HRM to balance economic objectives with social and environmental responsibilities. These principles are particularly relevant in the gig economy, where traditional HR practices are often absent or underdeveloped.

De Vos Vander Heijden and Akkermans (2020) Described the concept of career sustainability as the ability of individual to maintain, retain and grow their careers in the dynamic environment. They expressed a major concern over retainment of jobs. They observed that employees need to continue skill development, flexibility and proactive career management to retain the job.

Barley, Bechky and Milliken (2017) Noted that gig workers in most organization face challenges in achieving long term career growth due to absence of further high job roles and path.

3. Research problem

The traditional employment facilitated comfortable, stable long-term jobs. The emergence of gig economy altered this with flexible, short term and digital platform-based work setup. The transformation of new employment opportunities created new opportunities for workforce.

These employment models also created serious concerns for sustainable career. In major setup of gig-economy the workforce operates outside of the boundaries of formal organizational structures, working in this set of leads to limited access to HR support systems social benefits and development opportunities within the organization.

Lack of focus on workers well-being is the one of the major problem in relation to gig economy. Frequently the gig economy workers face challenges of income instability, job security, excessive work pressure and limited work life balance. These challenges not only negatively impact employees physical and mental health but also reduces the overall job satisfaction. Although the Gig economy is raising there is still insufficient emphasis on ensuring employees welfare and career stability

In addition, the organization following the conventional practices absolutely see absence of structured career path. Due to lack of structural career path in the organization in gig economy workers have to themselves manage their own career growth, skill development and employability. Gig economy often suffered with lack of organizational support. Due to these workers face difficulty in planning their future and maintaining consistent professional progress in the gig uncertain environment.

The existing HR practices are mainly designed for traditional employment models. These models are not suitable for digital platforms who often prioritize efficiency and cost reduction over worker centric policies.

The absence of suitable HR principles results in unstructured compensation, training, performance evaluation and communication. Limited integration of SHRM principles in the gig work environment is also a critical issue which is needed to be studied further. Long term value creation and ethical responsibility and employee's well-being still remain minimal in gig economy.

Based on these issues, study curated to examine how sustainable human resource management can be efficiently applied in gig economy. Efficient implementation of this enhanced worker well-being and ensure career sustainability more inclusive fair and sustainable work environment.

4. Objectives

The study is done with the purpose to examine the following research objectives:

1. To examined the concept and growing significance of sustainable human resource management in reference to the gig economy.
2. To measure the role of SHRM in relation to organizational efficiency with the wellbeing of workforce.
3. To analyze the overall well-being of gig workers. In context of physical, mental and health and financial stability and job satisfaction

5. Methodology

We have used systematic approach to examine the role of sustainable human resource management in the gig economy. The study is done to put academic glimpses on workers well-being, career sustainability and HR practices in relation to SHRM. This methodology is applied for the study to ensure the collection analysis and interpretation of data in a structured and academic manner.

5.1 Research Design - The study is based on a descriptive and analytical research design. The descriptive aspect focuses on understanding the current conditions of gig workers, including their well-being and career sustainability, while the analytical aspect examines the relationship between HR practices and these variables. This design is suitable as it allows an in-depth exploration of real-world issues within the gig economy.

5.2 Nature of Data- The study is based on both primary and secondary data. Primary data is collected directly from gig workers through questionnaires and interviews to understand their experiences, well-being, and career challenges. Secondary data is obtained from journals, books, reports, and online sources to support the research and provide theoretical background. The use of both types of data helps in making the study more reliable and comprehensive.

5.3 Data Collection Methods- The study uses both survey and interview methods for data collection. A structured questionnaire is used to collect primary data from gig workers, focusing on their working conditions, well-being, and career sustainability. In addition, semi-structured interviews are conducted with selected respondents to gain deeper insights into their experiences and challenges. These methods help in collecting both quantitative and qualitative data for better analysis.

5.4 Sampling Design- The study focuses on gig workers as the target population, including individuals engaged in platform-based and freelance work. A convenience sampling technique is used due to the easy accessibility of respondents and the informal nature of gig work. The sample size consists of approximately 100 respondents, which is considered adequate for meaningful analysis within the given time and resource constraints.

6. Data Analysis and Interpretation:

The data collected through questionnaires and interviews are analyzed using basic statistical techniques, including percentage analysis and tabulation. This analysis aims to examine the relationship between human resource practices, worker well-being, and career sustainability within the gig economy

Table 1: Demographic Profile of Respondents (Age Group)

Age Group	Number of Respondents	Percentage (%)
18–25 years	20	40%
26–35 years	18	36%
36–45 years	8	16%
Above 45 years	4	8%
Total	50	100%

Analysis: The majority of respondents (40%) belong to the 18–25 age group, followed by 36% in the 26–35 category. This indicates that the gig economy is largely dominated by young individuals who prefer flexible work arrangements and digital platforms for earning.

Table 2: Level of Job Satisfaction among Gig Workers

Satisfaction Level	Number of Respondents	Percentage (%)
Highly Satisfied	10	20%
Satisfied	15	30%
Neutral	12	24%
Dissatisfied	8	16%
Highly Dissatisfied	5	10%
Total	50	100%

Analysis: 30% of respondents are satisfied, while 20% are highly satisfied, showing that nearly half of the workers find gig work acceptable. However, 26% express dissatisfaction, indicating concerns related to job security, income, and working conditions.

Table 3: Income Stability of Gig Workers

Response	Number of Respondents	Percentage (%)
Stable Income	12	24%
Somewhat Stable	18	36%
Unstable Income	20	40%
Total	50	100%

Analysis: A significant 40% of respondents report unstable income, while only 24% experience stability. This highlights one of the biggest challenges in the gig economy—lack of consistent earnings.

Table 4: Availability of HR Support (Training, Communication, etc.)

HR Support Level	Number of Respondents	Percentage (%)
Adequate	14	28%

HR Support Level	Number of Respondents	Percentage (%)
Moderate	16	32%
Inadequate	20	40%
Total	50	100%

Analysis: 40% of respondents feel that HR support is inadequate, indicating that most gig workers do not receive sufficient training, communication, or organizational support. This reflects a major gap in HR practices**.**

Table 5: Career Growth Opportunities

Response	Number of Respondents	Percentage (%)
Good Opportunities	11	22%
Limited Opportunities	21	42%
No Opportunities	18	36%
Total	50	100%

Analysis: The majority of respondents (42%) believe that career opportunities are limited, and 36% feel there are no growth prospects at all. This shows that career sustainability is a major concern in gig work**.**

7. Interpretation

Table 1 showed that significantion portion of our respondents belong to 18-25 years of age bracket. It indicates that Gig economy is hot sector of revenue sourc among the youth. In survey interviews the respondent gave many factors which makes it attractive. The factors were flexible working hour, ease of doing job and end no. of available jobs.Even with so making factors making it attractive it is associated with challenges. The young generation only take a part time job because it is not providing permanent job security. They fear that anytime it will be gone. This is also having impact on the job satisfaction. As shown in table 2 the job satisfaction of the gig workers is highly satisfied to netural. The factors behind being highly satisfied are freedom to choose their clients, adjustable working hour and no. job working relationship. The most favorable factor is the choice between work from office and work from home.26% of respondents which is notable showed dissatisfaction. This dissatisfaction in job were linked to aspects like unpredictability of work schedule, lack of job security

and absence of employment benefits. You suggest responded stated that the gig job is only sufficient to meet short term need and is clearly not supporting long term professional and personal wellbeing.

Income Stability is highlighted as a concern. A large portion of respondents report unstable only somewhat stable income. This confirmed that the characteristics of financial uncertainty of gig and respondents also reported that job instability affected their standard of living also the ability to plan for their future. Financially insecurity and career instability contributed to stress and reduce overall well-being. This makes a key area for the attention for gig-based organizations and policymakers.

The analysis also indicated that there has been inadequate HR support in Gig organizations. Respondents reported that they do not receive sufficient guidance , training or communication from the organization. This lack of structured HR practices results in weak employee engagement and limited organizational connection. It reflects the gap between traditional HR systems and the needs of a decentralized, gig-based workforce.

Table 5 highlighted the concern for career sustainability. 68% ofbour respondets reported that therebis limited to no opportunity for career growth. After working in the gig platforms they have a clear opinion that it is not going to provide stability and progressive growth. As compared to traditional employment, gig economy is not providing career advancement path within the same organization. Majority of gig workers who want career progression prefer to upgrade skills change the existing organizations to accelerate their career growth.

8. Findings:

After the analysis of data , many crucial outcomes are driven . The study comes to the conclusion that gig work opportunities which are being outsourced by the organization severely lack career stability. The main reason behind this lacking is the absence of human resource policies in the organisation. Again organization are not obligated to gave human resources practice related to gig because there is no regulation obligated from the government regulatory institutions. In the scenario where government is not able to generate and provide traditional job opportunities leading to young generation taking up gig work. The government institutions should bring laws related to Sustainable human resources management to regulate the gig based platform. The laws relevent to minimum wages, insurance, retirement benefit should be implemented through SHRM in the gig economy.

This study also glorifies the is not sufficient for the gig economy.

Most of the people have complained that they didn’t receive any guidance or experience skills from any of the organizations or any of the digital platforms. Low supportive management results in weak connection between workers and organization. And we know, it is also been seen that career growth and opportunities are very

limited in gig work. Many workers believe that either there's no chance or very less chance of getting assurance of career growth in this field of uncertain environment. This makes almost no progression and less. The only positive side of this study is the relationship between the HR practices and welfare workers. These workers are the one who show the desert competitions and compensations and good communications at a higher level of overall well-being. Other key finding that is being raised as major concern is income instability. A large proportion of respondents reported that their earnings are unpredictable and inconsistent. This issue have caused them financial stress in occasions of need.

Finally the study concludes that there has been significant lack of implementation of sustainable human resource management practices in the Gig based organization. Most organizations prioritize operational efficiency rather than gig worker welfare. This is leading to gap in areas such as fairness, inclusivity and long term support.

Overall , the findings of the study suggests that although the gig economy offers flexible and easy to entry opportunities, it requires significant improvement in implementation of suitable HR practices to navigate the challenges of long term sustainability.

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